

Garage Door Repair Bill Shock — Action Checklist

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DIAGNOSE BEFORE CALLING

- ☐ **Diagnose Before Calling:** Test manual lifting by pulling the emergency release cord and lifting the door by hand to determine if springs are intact or if the problem lies in the opener and motor.
- ☐ **Diagnose Before Calling:** Check if the motor runs without moving the door to identify potential drive system failures in the gear, sprocket assembly, or belt that could be misdiagnosed as motor failure.
- ☐ **Diagnose Before Calling:** Inspect the infrared sensors at the base of the door frame and realign them until the indicator lights turn solid green if the door reopens immediately after closing.
- ☐ **Diagnose Before Calling:** Listen for grinding or popping noises during operation to distinguish between worn sprockets and fatigued springs so you describe the exact problem to contractors.

KNOW FAIR REPAIR COSTS

- ☐ **Know Fair Repair Costs:** Request an itemized quote that separately lists parts costs and labor charges for every repair estimate you receive, as bundled pricing can obscure excessive markups.
- ☐ **Know Fair Repair Costs:** Compare the quoted parts against standard price ranges for springs, openers, sensors, and circuit boards to identify inflated charges before signing anything.
- ☐ **Know Fair Repair Costs:** Ask contractors to specify the exact part name and model number instead of vague descriptions like 'the mechanism' so you can verify pricing independently.
- ☐ **Know Fair Repair Costs:** Verify that sensor misalignment is not being diagnosed as a circuit board or motor problem, which can add \$300-\$800 to your bill unnecessarily.

GET COMPETITIVE BIDS

- ☐ **Get Competitive Bids:** Obtain at least three written bids for any repair estimate exceeding \$300 to ensure fair pricing and create leverage against inflated quotes.
 - ☐ **Get Competitive Bids:** State explicitly when calling contractors that you are seeking itemized written quotes and comparing multiple estimates to encourage more competitive pricing.
 - ☐ **Get Competitive Bids:** Inquire about service call fees upfront and ask whether the diagnostic charge applies toward the final repair cost to avoid surprise charges later.
 - ☐ **Get Competitive Bids:** Question any contractor who recommends full replacement by asking what repair would cost and why replacement is necessary instead of accepting their recommendation immediately.
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